around and catch them. In these countries, they keep elephants for drawing carriages (or, riding). Wolves, rhinoceros, and black leopards are abundant, so men dare not go' into the forests.

In Maharashtra, 'the disposition of the people is honest and simple', though they also have 'a stern and vindictive character. To their benefactors they are grateful; to their enemies relentless'. On one hand, 'if they are insulted, they will risk their lives to avenge themselves', on the other 'if they are asked to help one in distress, they will forget themselves in their haste to render assistance'. In war, if one of their generals loses, 'they do not inflict punishment, but present him with woman's clothes, and so he is driven to seek death for himself'. This country also has several hundred fierce warriors, 'a band of champions', who enter battle after they and their elephants have drunk enough alcohol. 'No enemy can [then] stand before them', including Harsha's mighty troops. Every time these revered champions 'go forth they beat drums before them', and if one of them kills a fellow citizen in a brawl, 'the laws of the country do not punish him'.

In Mathura, Xuanzang finds lots of stupas, monasteries and Buddhists; its people are 'soft and complacent' and 'esteem virtue and learning'. Faxian too visited Mathura, c. 406 CE, noting that there were twenty monasteries on both the banks of the Yamuna, with perhaps 'three thousand monks; and [here] the Law of Buddha was still more flourishing'. Indeed, even in the second century CE, Mathura was the production hub of the earliest Buddha statues in the north, especially for the major Buddhist sites of Shravasti, Kausambi and Sarnath.[21]

South of Mathura is the 'Middle Kingdom', writes Faxian. 'The people are numerous and happy; they have not to register their households, or attend to any magistrates and their rules; only those who cultivate the royal land have to pay [a portion of] the grain from it.[*] If they want to go, they go; if they want to stay on, they stay. The king governs without decapitation or [other] corporal punishments.[†] Criminals are simply fined, lightly or heavily, according to the circumstances [of each case]. Even in cases of repeated attempts at wicked rebellion, they only have their right hands cut off.' This was the realm of the Gupta Empire (319–543 CE).

In Magadh (in present-day Bihar), Faxian writes, 'The cities and towns . . . are the greatest of all in the Middle Kingdom. The inhabitants are rich and